

THE RETURN OF THE KING

EVERYTHING YOU WANTED TO KNOW ABOUT THE LONG-AWAITED MARUTI SUZUKI JIMNY, INCLUDING A TEST OF ITS OFF-ROAD PROWESS

BY RAHUL GHOSH

The Jimny existed earlier as a three-door model, but, somehow, Maruti Suzuki thought that wasn't apt for India. So, the company has created a brand new, 5-door version. The new Jimny looks very much like the older version, and, as a result, comes with boxy proportions and a nearly bug-eye-like front-end design. The short bumpers are chiselled much like proper off-road bumpers and, thus, the SUV gets generous ramp over angles. In profile, one can spot the flared wheel arches and the extended wheelbase as compared to the three-door version. While the front door is similar in size, the rear one is a small unit that allows access to the back seat. The only odd sight is the 15-inch wheels, which look small for the SUV. While at first glance, the tyres might look and feel inadequate for off-road use considering they are HT, a closer look reveals they have been made especially for use in sand and snow. At the back, the side-hinged door houses the spare tyre and the tail-lights have been positioned on the bumpers. Overall, the car looks quite boxy and cute.

The wide-opening doors allow for easy ingress. The low, lip-less floor makes things even better. Inside, the Jimny feels compact but not claustrophobic. One can see the bonnet ends, making it easy to drive in the city. The dash is small and the glovebox easily accessible. The infotainment system sits in the model and offers Apple and Android connectivity. However, it does not offer off-road-based info, which one gets in the Thar. The instrument panel is a classic affair, reminding one of the Gypsy. It is a two-pod unit with an analogue tacho and speedo plus a digital MID. The centre console houses buttons for the power windows, TC and HDC. Right next to it are the gear lever and the 4wd lever, and two cup-holders. This is where the Jimny could have been better by offering a little more space for things within the cabin. The seats up front are comfortable and offer generous adjustability options. Getting into the back is a breeze too. The space is enough for two, though three will be a crowd. But where the Jimny scores again is the boot. It offers a low loading height and a generous 211 litres of boot space.

Engine: 1.5 L petrol
Power: 105 bhp@6,000rpm
Price: Rs 12.74-14.89 lakh (ex-showroom)

Maruti Suzuki has decided to play old-school and endowed the Jimny with the K15B naturally-aspirated petrol engine. The motor displaces 1,462 cc and churns out 105 bhp and 134 Nm of torque. Power is sent to the wheels using a 4-speed automatic. The Jimny starts up with a familiar degree of smoothness; it also takes off smoothly and gets to 60 kmph quickly. Between 60 kmph and 80 kmph is where the sweet spot lies, and this means it is extremely smooth to drive in city conditions. Nevertheless, it can also effortlessly cruise at 120 kmph.

Though the SUV itself feels lightweight, the steering doesn't. It is unnaturally heavy and slow on the go. So, changing turns needs a bit of effort.

But where the Jimny scores is ride quality. In spite of being an old-school ladder frame setup, the ride is sublime. The suspension soaks up bumps and ruts with ease. There is a good bout of body roll and understeer characteristics, but, overall, it is a joy to drive.

The car takes on the rough stuff smoothly and the small dimensions make negotiating smaller trails easy. The Jimny comes with HT tyres, and unless one plans to go really hardcore, there is no need for a tyre change. You truly don't need to work too hard with the Jimny. ■